

SUBSTANCE ABUSE NEGATIVE IMPACT VERSUS SOBRIETY'S POSITIVE IMPACT

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Break down denial and minimization by acknowledging the negative consequences of substance abuse.
2. Increase hope and motivation for sobriety by recognizing the potential positive consequences of recovery.
3. Commit to a recovery program that will promote sobriety.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Chemical Dependence—Relapse

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Breaking through denial for a chemically dependent client is a difficult task. This assignment provides an opportunity for the client to assess the devastating effects of substance abuse on his/her life and the lives of others. Confrontation may be used if minimization or denial prevents honest acknowledgment of the negative consequences surrounding the client's substance abuse pattern. Reinforcement and support should be given as honesty is demonstrated. Assistance may be necessary to provide the chemically dependent client with a vision of the positive impact of sobriety on his/her future since it is not unusual for hopelessness and helplessness to predominate.

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To maintain a life of sobriety, you need to acknowledge without denial and minimization the negative impact that substance abuse has had on your life and the lives of others. In contrast to that, you accept that sobriety will have a positive impact on your life and the lives of others. This assignment gives you an opportunity to honestly evaluate the negative consequences of your history of substance abuse and project how sobriety will produce positive consequences for you and others.

1. List at least 10 ways that your substance abuse has negatively impacted your life. Consider such things as health, relationships, self-esteem, employment, legal entanglements, finances, friendships, family relations, children, and so on.

- A. _____

- B. _____

- C. _____

- D. _____

- E. _____

- F. _____

- G. _____

- H. _____

- I. _____

J. _____

K. _____

L. _____

2. List at least 10 ways that your substance abuse has had a negative impact on the lives of others. Consider friends, family, employers, children, coworkers, neighbors, counselors, clergy, AA members, sponsors, and so on. (Be sure to indicate not just who was affected by your substance abuse, but *how* they were affected.)

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____

D. _____

E. _____

F. _____

G. _____

H. _____

I. _____

J. _____

K. _____

L. _____

3. List at least 10 positive impacts that being sober will have on your life. Consider the same areas that you reviewed in number 1.

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____

D. _____

E. _____

F. _____

G. _____

H. _____

I. _____

J. _____

K. _____

L. _____

4. List at least 10 ways that being sober will have a positive impact on the lives of others. Consider those same people that you thought of for number 2.

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____

D. _____

- E. _____
- F. _____
- G. _____
- H. _____
- I. _____
- J. _____
- K. _____
- L. _____

5. List the three most important negative consequences of your substance abuse on your life. Select these from number 1.

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____

Why have you chosen these as the most important? _____

6. List the three most important negative consequences that your substance abuse has had on others. Select these from number 2.

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____

Why have you chosen these as the most important? _____

7. List the three most important positive consequences of sobriety in your personal life. Select these from number 3.

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____

Why have you chosen these as the most important? _____

8. List the three most important positive consequences of sobriety on the lives of others. Select these from number 4.

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____

Why have you chosen these as the most important? _____

9. What changes can you make in your life to reduce the probability that substance abuse will continue along with its negative consequences and increase the probability that sobriety will be maintained along with its positive consequences?
